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# The Merchant War

## An Adventure for Fate's Edge Silkstrand

### Adventure Overview

**Title:** The Merchant War  
**Region:** Silkstrand City of Bridges  
Dyewater  
**Theme:** Economic warfare, social manipulation, urban intrigue  
**Level:** Seasoned (Tier II)  
**Length:** 34 Sessions

### 1 Premise

Two powerful merchant houses in Silkstrand are engaged in an escalating economic war that's disrupting trade throughout the region. What began as competitive business practices has evolved into sabotage, assassination, and manipulation of the city's political structure. The players must navigate this conflict while pursuing their own objectives, choosing sides or finding a way to end the war before it destroys the city's economy entirely.

### 2 Hook

The adventure begins when the players encounter one of the following scenarios (Investigation + Notice vs DV 3 to determine truth):

tem **Cargo Seizure:** Their cargo is seized at the docks due to a "regulatory dispute" between the two merchant houses, requiring them to navigate the political maze to recover their goods. (Legal/Social challenge, Sway + Command vs DV 4) tem **Botched Job:** A contact offers them a lucrative job that involves retrieving sensitive information from the rival merchant house, but the job goes wrong and they become targets. (Infiltration/Combat encounter, DV 5) tem **Witness to Violence:** They witness an assassination attempt on a prominent merchant, making them both witnesses and potential targets in the escalating conflict. (Combat/Skill challenge, DV 4)

### 3 Key Factions

#### 3.1 House Valdris

House Valdris tem[Leader:] Guildmistress Thalia Valdris tem[Description:] Traditional merchant house controlling dye trade tem[Strengths:] Established connections, dye monopoly, political influence tem[Weaknesses:] Resistant to change, declining popular support tem[Methods:] Legal

maneuvering, political pressure, traditional sabotage tem[Symbol:] Purple and silver tem[Position:] Dominant (established authority), Desperate (losing ground) tem[DV for Alliance:] 4 (mutual benefit), 5 (neutral), 6+ (opposed)

### 3.2 Crimson Sails Trading Company

Crimson Sails Trading Company tem[Leader:] CaptainMerchant Renn Kestral tem[Description:] Aggressive newcomer disrupting traditional trade tem[Strengths:] Naval power, innovative practices, popular with younger merchants tem[Weaknesses:] Limited political connections, viewed as upstarts tem[Methods:] Economic warfare, bribery, direct action tem[Symbol:] Crimson and gold tem[Position:] Dominant (popular momentum), Controlled under legal pressure tem[DV for Alliance:] 3 (shared goals), 4 (neutral), 5+ (opposed)

## large4 Key NPCs

### 4.1 Guildmistress Thalia Valdris

Guildmistress Thalia Valdris tem[Role:] Leader of House Valdris tem[Age:] 54 tem[Skills:] Command 4, Sway 3, Lore 3 tem[Knowledge:] Traditional trade practices, political connections, legal precedents tem[Motivation:] Preserve established order and family legacy tem[Complication:] Becoming increasingly desperate as Crimson Sails gains ground tem[Position:] Controlled (established authority), Desperate (under pressure) tem[DV for Negotiation:] 4 (mutual benefit), 5 (neutral), 6+ (opposed)

### 4.2 CaptainMerchant Renn Kestral

CaptainMerchant Renn Kestral tem[Role:] Leader of Crimson Sails Trading Company tem[Age:] 42 tem[Skills:] Command 3, Sway 4, Skirmish 2 tem[Knowledge:] Naval operations, innovative trade practices, popular sentiment tem[Motivation:] Disrupt traditional corruption and create new opportunities tem[Complication:] Former corsair background creates legal vulnerabilities tem[Position:] Dominant (popular support), Controlled under political pressure tem[DV for Partnership:] 3 (shared goals), 4 (neutral), 5+ (opposed)

### 4.3 Matron Esme Blackwater

Matron Esme Blackwater tem[Role:] Nominal ruler of Silkstrand tem[Age:] 67 tem[Skills:] Command 4, Insight 3, Sway 3 tem[Knowledge:] City governance, faction dynamics, longterm consequences tem[Motivation:] Maintain city stability and prosperity tem[Complication:] Limited direct power, must work through factions tem[Position:] Dominant (legitimate authority), Controlled (dependent on factions) tem[DV for Audience:] 4 (legitimate request), 5 (neutral), 6+ (opposition)

### 4.4 The Broker

The Broker tem[Role:] Secret manipulator fueling conflict tem[Skills:] Subterfuge 4, Sway 4, Insight 3 tem[Knowledge:] Secrets of both factions, conflict manipulation methods tem[Motivation:] Profit from ongoing conflict through facilitation tem[Complication:] Maintains cover while manipulating both sides tem[Position:] Controlled (operating in shadows), Desperate if exposed tem[DV for Information:] 5 (secrecy), 4 (proper approach), 3 (trusted ally)

## large5 Key Locations

### 5.1 ThreeQueens Bridge

ThreeQueens Bridge tem[Description:] Central marketplace and faction battleground tem[Features:] Multiple levels, vendor stalls, observation points tem[Conflict Zone:] Business disputes escalate to violence tem[Challenges:]

tem Navigating faction tensions (Social challenge, DV 4) tem Participating in Bridge Duel Protocol (Combat/Skill, varies) tem Gathering intelligence from vendors (Sway + Insight vs DV 3)

tem[Position:] Controlled (normal), Desperate (during faction clashes)

### 5.2 The Dye Works

The Dye Works tem[Description:] House Valdris's primary dye production facility tem[Features:] Complex chemical processes, valuable trade secrets, heavy security tem[Security Level:] High guarded facility with restricted access tem[Challenges:]

tem Infiltrating secured areas (Stealth + Tinker vs DV 5) tem Sabotaging production processes (Tinker + Subterfuge vs DV 6) tem Gathering trade secrets (Investigation vs DV 5)

tem[Protection Measures:] Patrols, guard dogs, alarm systems

### 5.3 The Crimson Docks

The Crimson Docks tem[Description:] Crimson Sails' naval base and ship maintenance hub tem[Features:] Fast ships, naval equipment, maritime activity tem[Security Level:] Medium patrolled area with naval protocols tem[Challenges:]

tem Boarding ships undetected (Stealth + Survival vs DV 4) tem Interfering with ship operations (Tinker + Subterfuge vs DV 5) tem Gathering naval intelligence (Sway + Notice vs DV 3)

tem[Naval Code:] Specific conduct rules for visitors and workers

### 5.4 The Archivolt

The Archivolt tem[Description:] Bureaucratic heart where contracts and disputes are settled tem[Features:] Legal archives, advocate offices, bureaucratic procedures tem[Complexity:] Maze of legal precedents and procedures tem[Challenges:]

tem Navigating legal bureaucracy (Lore + Sway vs DV 5) tem Winning legal cases (Command + Lore vs DV 5) tem Researching faction histories (Investigation vs DV 4)

tem[Access Requirements:] Proper documentation or influential connections

### 5.5 The Salt Gate Quay

The Salt Gate Quay tem[Description:] Main import/export facility controlling trade flows tem[Features:] Cargo handling, customs operations, strategic importance tem[Strategic Value:] Control means control of trade routes tem[Challenges:]

tem Influencing customs operations (Sway + Command vs DV 4) tem Sabotaging cargo operations (Tinker + Subterfuge vs DV 5) tem Coordinating with dock workers (Social challenge, DV 3)

tem[Recent Issues:] "Accidents" disrupting normal operations

## 6 Plot Structure

### 6.1 Session 1: Entanglement

**Opening Scene:** Players encounter one of the hook scenarios. Establish the immediate effects of merchant warfare.

**Key Objectives:**

tem Experience direct effects of economic warfare tem Meet representatives from both factions tem Learn conflict's origins and current state tem Make initial choices about faction support

**Sample Encounters:**

tem **Regulatory Dispute:** Navigate legal maze to recover seized cargo. (Sway + Lore vs DV 4, Controlled/Standard) tem **Faction Recruitment:** Both houses attempt to recruit players. (Social encounter, DV 35 depending on approach) tem **Marketplace Tension:** Experience faction conflict at ThreeQueens Bridge. (Social/Combat encounter, DV 4)

**Session End:** Players committed to one side or maintaining neutrality. Advance Merchant War Timer +1.

### 6.2 Session 2: Deepening Involvement

**Opening Scene:** Players take on more significant faction roles. Conflict escalates visibly.

**Key Objectives:**

tem Complete missions for chosen faction (or both) tem Experience escalating consequences of war tem Discover secrets about both houses tem Face moral dilemmas about involvement

**Sample Encounters:**

tem **Sabotage Mission:** Infiltrate rival facility to gather intelligence or cause disruption. (Stealth + Tinker vs DV 5, Desperate/Standard) tem **Legal Battle:** Represent faction in Archivolt proceedings. (Command + Lore vs DV 5, Controlled/Great) tem **Assassination Attempt:** Defend or attack key faction figure. (Combat encounter, DV 5)

**Session End:** Players gain significant faction influence. Advance Merchant War Timer +2, shift Reputation Tracks.

### 6.3 Session 3: The Breaking Point

**Opening Scene:** Conflict reaches crisis point threatening city stability.

**Key Objectives:**

tem Deal with consequences of previous actions tem Make crucial decisions about conflict resolution tem Potentially face secret manipulator (The Broker) tem Determine future of Silkstrand's merchant community

**Sample Encounters:**

tem **CityWide Crisis:** Deal with economic disruption affecting civilians. (Leadership challenge, DV 5) tem **The Broker's Revelation:** Confront secret manipulator. (Social/Combat encounter, DV 6) tem **Final Negotiation:** Broker peace or decisive victory. (Sway + Command vs DV 6, Desperate/Great)

**Session End:** Major conflict resolution. Advance Merchant War Timer to culmination.

**large7 Key Mechanics****7.1 Merchant War Timer [8]**

tem[Advance +1:] Economic sabotage successfully executed tem[Advance +1:] Assassinations or violent incidents occur tem[Advance +2:] Political maneuvering fails spectacularly tem[Advance +1:] Players make choices that escalate conflict tem[Advance +2:] Key faction leaders suffer major setbacks tem[Advance +1:] Civilian casualties or economic disruption tem[When Full:] Conflict reaches breaking point, city stability threatened

**7.2 Reputation Tracks**

tem[House Valdris Track:] Traditionalist  $\longleftrightarrow$  Rebel tem[Crimson Sails Track:] Corrupt  $\longleftrightarrow$  Progressive tem[Movement:] Player actions shift tracks by  $\pm 1$  per significant interaction tem[Effects:]

tem High Traditionalist/Progressive: +1 die to faction interactions tem High Rebel/Corrupt: 1 die to opposing faction interactions tem Extreme positions: Access to special missions or complete rejection

**7.3 Bridge Duel Protocol**

tem[Trigger:] Business disputes escalate to violence on ThreeQueens Bridge tem[Stakes Declaration:] Choose Purse (money), Permit (legal right), or Pride (reputation) tem[Seconds:] May spend 1 Boon to "Call the Colors" (improve Position by 1 step) tem[Refusal Consequences:] Automatic reputation damage (1 die to social rolls with faction) tem[Resolution:] Standard combat rules with declared stakes determining consequences

**7.4 Exchange MiniGame**

tem[Setup:] Track scenelong Spread (starts at 1) tem[Actions:] Each good call on trading floor moves Spread by  $\pm 1$  tem[Cash Out:] Gain Price Edge tag (+1 die) when buying/selling during scene tem[Skills Used:] Sway, Notice, Insight for reading market tem[DV:] 3 (basic trading), 4 (complex deals), 5+ (highstakes negotiations)

**large8 Possible Resolutions****8.1 Faction Victory**

Faction Victory tem[Requirements:]

tem Complete major sabotage mission against rival (Tinker + Subterfuge vs DV 6) tem Win crucial legal case in Archivolt (Command + Lore vs DV 6) tem Eliminate key leadership of opposing faction (Combat/Skill vs DV 5)

tem[Procedure:] Decisive action giving one faction overwhelming advantage tem[Costs:] City's balance of power shifts dangerously, potential for future rebellion tem[Outcome:] Winner gains control, but creates new tensions and dependencies

## 8.2 Negotiated Settlement

Negotiated Settlement tem[Discovery:] Expose The Broker's manipulation and secret influence tem[Requirements:]

tem Gather evidence of manipulation (Investigation vs DV 5) tem Convince both factions of mutual benefit (Sway + Command vs DV 5) tem Gain Matron's support for intervention (Social challenge, DV 4)

tem[Procedure:] Complex threeway negotiation with city authority backing tem[Costs:] Both houses must compromise, ongoing oversight required tem[Outcome:] Stable business environment, mutual obligations to players

## 8.3 Revolutionary Change

Revolutionary Change tem[Approach:] Overthrow old system entirely, create new governance tem[Requirements:]

tem Expose corruption in both houses (Investigation + Subterfuge vs DV 5) tem Rally common merchants and workers (Command + Sway vs DV 5) tem Install new form of governance (Political challenge, DV 6)

tem[Procedure:] Popular uprising with player leadership tem[Costs:] Complete upheaval with uncertain future, potential for chaos tem[Outcome:] New order with player influence, but ongoing instability

# 9 Rewards and Consequences

## 9.1 Immediate Rewards

tem Bridge token for peakhour cart crossing: +1 Position for bridge navigation tem Dyepermit chit to process "questionable" color: Legal authority for special dyes tem Warehouse seal from winning faction: Access to premium storage facilities tem Exchange pass for trading without sponsor: Independent trading privileges tem Watergate priority to skip closures: Priority access to restricted areas

## 9.2 Longterm Consequences

tem **Faction Victory:** Permanent business relationship with winner, access to resources, but enemies in losing faction tem **Negotiated Settlement:** Reputation as stabilizing force, mutual obligations from both houses, stable trading environment tem **Revolutionary Change:** Potential leadership roles in new order, great personal power but ongoing responsibility tem **Neutral Outcome:** Maintained independence but limited faction access, potential for future recruitment by either side

## large10 GM Notes

### 10.1 Social Dynamics

Emphasize social aspects of conflict:

- tem Every interaction has social stakes and longterm consequences
- tem Reputation affects access to resources and opportunities
- tem Social manipulation as important as economic warfare
- tem Class tensions between old nobility and new merchants

### 10.2 Economic Realities

Make economic warfare tangible:

- tem Rising prices affecting ordinary citizens
- tem Job losses and business closures throughout city
- tem Disrupted supply chains creating shortages
- tem Economic pressure driving people to extreme measures

### 10.3 Moral Ambiguity

Present complex moral landscape:

- tem Neither faction entirely good or evil
- tem House Valdris: Stability vs. resistance to progress
- tem Crimson Sails: Innovation vs. disruption of communities
- tem Players face genuine moral choices with consequences

### 10.4 Player Agency

Provide multiple paths to influence conflict:

- tem Work for one side exclusively
- tem Play both sides against each other
- tem Work to end war entirely
- tem Create third option through revolutionary change
- tem Focus on personal objectives while navigating conflict

### 10.5 Urban Environment

Use Silkstrand's unique features:

- tem Bridges create vertical complexity and strategic points
- tem Dyeworks provide industrial hazards and valuable resources
- tem Waterways offer transportation and smuggling routes
- tem Archivolt represents bureaucratic maze and legal complexity

### 10.6 Story Beats

Use economic conflict for complications:

- tem 1 SB: Minor business disruption, small price fluctuation
- tem 2 SB: Key contact becomes suspicious, shipment delayed
- tem 3 SB: Major sabotage incident, faction leader threatened
- tem 4+ SB: Citywide economic crisis, faction headquarters attacked



## 10.7 SessionSpecific Guidance

**Session 1 Focus:** Establish conflict dynamics and player involvement. Players should understand both factions have strengths and weaknesses.

**Session 2 Focus:** Deepen faction involvement and escalate consequences. Players gain significant influence but face moral complexity.

**Session 3 Focus:** Climactic resolution with citywide implications. All previous elements converge in final choices about Silkstrand's future.

## 10.8 Alternative Endings

If players attempt unconventional solutions:

tem **Information Broker Path:** Become neutral facilitator profiting from both sides tem

**City Guardian Role:** Work directly for Matron to maintain balance tem **Foreign Inter-**

**vention:** Invite external power to resolve conflict tem **Economic Innovation:** Create new business model transcending faction divide

## 10.9 Scaling for Different Tiers

**Tier II (Seasoned):** Standard economic and social challenges, local city scope.

**Tier III (Veteran):** Add regional political implications, foreign trade complications, and more powerful faction resources.

**Tier IV (Paragon):** Introduce international trade war consequences, faction gains patron backing, threat to entire trade network.